

AN AFFAIR TO REMEMBER

The tempestuous relationship between Rossellini and an Indian woman, and how Nehru helped them flee



UNDER HER SPELL: ROBERTO ROSSellini IN INDIA
by DILEEP PADGAONKAR
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■ By Sunil Sethi

In early December 1956, Roberto Rossellini, the pioneer of neorealist Italian cinema, arrived in India with 100 kilos of spaghetti in his luggage and armfuls of research notes. He was not interested in sightseeing; he turned his face away from the Taj and stayed in the car while his colleagues visited Ajanta. It was the high noon of Nehruvianism and the 50-year-old filmmaker had come at the invitation of the prime minister to make a series of films on the new realities facing independent India. Rossellini's post-War trilogy—*Rome Open City*, *Paisan* and *Germany, Year Zero* or films with his mercurial lover Anna Magnani—were behind him, and he was eager to leave behind his troubled life. His acolytes at the influential film journal *Cahiers du Cinema* in Paris, principally Truffaut and Godard, had other fish to fry; his tempestuous marriage to the Hollywood star Ingrid Bergman was on the rocks.

A major scandal had erupted some years earlier when Bergman, the adored heroine of *Casablanca* and Hitchcock movies, had left her Swedish husband and daughter to make films with Rossellini in Europe and have his children. America came down hard on the adulterous couple, leading to denunciations on the floor of the US Senate. Bergman was declared *persona non grata*. She went on to win three Oscars and seven nominations but John Gielgud was unimpressed: "She speaks five languages and can't act in any of them."

A maestro of 20th-century film, Rossellini brought a touch

of the Rabelaisian banquet to life. His films were made on low budgets, used mostly non-professional actors and threw narrative conventions of scripting to the winds. His larger-than-life appetites, though, had been fed by being the spoilt son of a wealthy Roman. He was a mesmeric talker, his intellectual and volatile temperament fuelled by dangerous seductions, fast Ferraris and a thirst for publicity and drama. Adeptly working the circuit he charmed the elite (M.F. Husain, Satyajit Ray, Romesh and Raj Thapar and Naval Tata were entranced) and persuaded Nehru and his ministers to put a production and travel budget, and a talented Films Division crew, at his disposal. He loathed the Hindi film industry and was contemptuous of the glittering *Mughal-e-Azam* set. The industry robustly returned his insults, magnified many times over. But like his friend Jean Renoir, Rossellini believed that all commercial industries like Hollywood "need is a good bombing".

HEART OF THE MATTER: Rossellini and Sonali at their house in Rome



Nine months later, after travelling thousands of miles and exposing many more thousands of feet of film, Rossellini's Indian sojourn ended in tears. His attempt to "grasp life in the fullness of its truth" exploded in a sexual scandal more incendiary than his relationship with Bergman. He had fallen in love with Sonalini (Sonali) Dasgupta, the reticent, Santiniketan-educated wife of documentary filmmaker Hari Dasgupta. Rossellini's pursuit of Sonali, the mother of two small boys, her arrival late one night at The Taj in Bombay with a babe in arms, became the stuff of international headlines and film folklore.

David Lean had gone off with an Indian woman not long before. "What Do Our Men See in These Hindoos," thundered Louella Parsons, the powerful columnist for Hearst newspapers. The foreign press laid siege at The Taj; the Indian media, led by Baburao Patel's *Filmindia* and R.K. Karanjia's *Blitz*, ran a vicious campaign of xenophobia and lurid titillation. Sonali's aunt was Bimal Roy's wife. Roy, cinematically speaking, was Rossellini's distant Indian descendant. She petitioned the prime minister and took to the streets. Until Dileep Padgaonkar's assiduous research, the extent of Nehru's involvement in this episode of film history was not known—nor how he helped the couple flee India with Sonali's child and Rossellini's footage. He has his scoop there.

Padgaonkar is a knowledgeable, curious and witty chronicler. With great aplomb, he places the wound of the Indo-European scandal in a larger context: of intellectual affinity and cultural dissonance, the drive of creative genius, and most of all, the web of illusion and deceit that lurks beneath love stories. Film buffs will find his account irresistible—but everyone else will lap it up, too.